PRESS RELEASE

May 5th 2023

The International Buddhist Association of America (IBAA) is delighted to announce the third lighting of lamps in the White House Indian Treaty Room in honor of the Buddhist festival of Vesak, the full moon day of May that marks the day of the Buddha's birth, enlightenment and passing away. The event was hosted by the Second Gentleman, and ambassadors from the countries of Cambodia, Nepal, Thailand and Sri Lanka were present, alongside delegations from India, Indonesia and Mongolia and representatives of the IBAA.

The Press release issued by the White House concerning the gathering is appended hereto.

According to the Pew Research Center there are more than 3.5 million Buddhists with over 2400 organizations in the U.S., making it our country's third largest religious tradition. Vesak—in various national forms—has been observed by millions of Buddhists throughout the world for millennia. In 1999, the United Nations recognized it as a major world religious holiday.

Mrs Wangmo Dixey, President IBAA commented: "*With between 700 million and a billion followers, Buddhism is the third of the great missionary religions, along with Christianity and Islam, and brings a message of perhaps unique importance to the cultural conditions we find today. The International Buddhist Association of America was founded to rise to this challenge, the challenge of bringing together all the various Buddhist voices found in America, and promoting the civilized and reasoned discourse that is such a feature of our great tradition.*"

For further information please contact Wangmo Dixey on 510 847 3649